amphibians which make the eco-system. So please don't wait only for the tigers but enjoy watching other animals too. And remember you shouldn't speak loudly" said Manimaran.

In a few minutes they had a chance to see a beautiful pond with lotus. The vehicle was moving slowly. The lotuses were smiling back at them. "Lotuses are of different types. Those which are pink are called pink lotuses. The lotus has a very special structure" said Veena.

Just behind a big tree near the pond, a peacock was fanning out its feathers gracefully. Without making noise, Velan and Ponni were admiring it. "Uncle Manimaran, usually peacocks do this during rainy days. Will it rain now?" said Ponni.

"Maybe. It dances only during rainy days. But once a chieftain Began, wondered whether the peacock was shivering in cold and covered the peacock with his shawl. This chieftain belonged to the classical Sangam age of Tamils and also revered as one of the seven most generous personalities of ancient Tamil land.



DO YOU KNOW?

There is a Peacock Sanctuary at Viralimalai in the district of Pudukottai (Tamilnadu)

"You know very well that the peacock is our national bird. For a long time the Peacock has a significant place in our culture, art and heritage. It's beauty, stately appearance and its even distribution all over India makes it our national bird" said Manimaran.

The vehicle moved forward silently. They admired the beauty on either side even without blinking.

"We have come very close to the bank of the river. Now we have to go along the river. I am going to show you a different animal. You have to remain silent; only then you can see it. Please take your binoculars" said Manimaran.

Veena had instructed the team to bring their binoculars on the visit. Velan and Ponni had borrowed the binoculars from their neighbours. They focused their binoculars towards the gap between the bushes. That gave them a view of the river. Veena said, "Look, there is something black like a Gharial crocodile moving". They could not see the animal clearly due to the glare caused by the morning sun. Manimaran said, "Turn away from the Sun's rays and watch carefully. It is not a Gharial".

Veena said, "No it does not look like a fish. It looks like an aquatic mammal – a river dophin".

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